TechnologyQ3: Should We Be Polite To ChatGPT?

Introduction

In principle, we should be polite to ChatGPT. Before explaining why, I want to define two terms. In this essay, I define politeness not as excessive courtesy or emotional suppression, but as the absence of impoliteness: not humiliating, and not turning frustration into contempt. The “should” here is not a legal command, and it is not a duty owed to ChatGPT. It is a standard of self-command: a person should be able to govern his own speech even when the object before him cannot suffer or retaliate. Freedom here depends on whether the user can still govern the expression he calls his own.

This essay will explain why we should treat ChatGPT with politeness by disproving a series of counterarguments. The first counterargument is that ChatGPT has no consciousness, so politeness toward it is merely emotional projection. The second is that users know ChatGPT is only a machine, so rudeness toward it will not affect their relationships with real people. The third is that rudeness toward ChatGPT is a free private choice. The fourth is that venting at ChatGPT may be safer than venting at a person. The final objection is that politeness loses meaning when directed at something that cannot receive respect.

These objections are important because they correctly deny that ChatGPT has a right to be respected. I do not claim that ChatGPT has dignity, pain, or interests that can be violated, and I do not claim that society should legally prohibit people from insulting AI. But the question is not whether ChatGPT is harmed. The question is what happens to the user, and to the technological environment, when contempt becomes easy.

After establishing that this is not about ChatGPT’s rights, the essay makes two further arguments. First, low-consequence rudeness can damage the user’s habits. A person who repeatedly practices contempt in a setting where no one resists him may become less able to govern his own expression. Second, rudeness toward ChatGPT may also affect other users’ habits because chatbots exist inside feedback systems. If users teach a chatbot to respond smoothly to anger or contempt, the system may make that pattern easier for others to enter. ChatGPT does not need politeness; the person using it needs the discipline that politeness preserves.

1.This is NOT About ChatGPT's Rights

The first opposing argument is that ChatGPT is not a person. That judgment is correct. In "Robots Should Be Slaves", Joanna J. Bryson warns that artifacts are first of all human-made systems, and should not easily be elevated into personal subjects.[1] ChatGPT has neither pain nor interests that can be violated. The question is therefore not whether I have harmed it. The question is how have I trained myself by using an object that cannot be hurt.

In Immanuel Kant's assessment of animal rights, the question of whether an object has rights does not exhaust the moral meaning of conduct; cruelty can weaken the agent's own capacity for feeling.[2] ChatGPT has a lower moral status than animals, but the structure is still clear: just because an object lacks rights, the agent can still be affected by interactions with an object.

Therefore, the main issue is not the object's claim against us, but the agent's relation to his own expression. If a person restrains himself only when he can be punished, that restraint is merely risk calculation. Only when a person faces something that cannot strike back and still does not surrender himself to rage does he show that he has the capacity to control himself.

2.Low Consequences Still Train the Self

The second opposing argument says: I know I am insulting a machine, so this will not affect my communication with real people. However, this underestimates how habits shape human interaction. In Book II of the Nicomachean Ethics, Aristotle says that people form the corresponding character by doing the corresponding acts;[3] Callard explains this habit as a positive feedback loop: action changes the emotional starting point of the next action;[4] Annas understands virtue as a skill that can improve and also deteriorate.[5] ChatGPT is not human, yet it gives enough conversational cues to activate human scripts of frustration; if the error to contempt then degradation chain is practiced where no one resists and nothing is lost, contempt becomes easier for the user in future interactions.

ChatGPT is especially capable of producing this repetition. It apologizes, but it may still continue to misunderstand, and it will not truly take responsibility. Byron Reeves and Clifford Nass had already pointed out that people bring social responses into media interactions;[6] after ELIZA, Joseph Weizenbaum also worried that people would project understanding onto language programs.[7] ChatGPT inherits this contradiction: it is like an other, but does not offer the resistance of an other. Just as repeated behavior can form bodily habits, repeated emotional responses can also become habits. Through repetition, it becomes a chain of reactions -- error, correction, further error.

Chatbots are always willing to play the same game with people and often affirm their ideas.[8] Human relationships, however, are full of disagreement.[9] AI itself is not real, but it shapes real people. It makes people face less opposing pressure; over time, people may grow accustomed to a form of interaction with no real resistance.

This opposing argument emphasizes “I can distinguish between machines and people”. Of course, that distinction exists, but distinction does not guarantee immunity from influence. Merel Keijsers, Friederike Eyssel, and Christoph Bartneck analyzed 283 real Cleverbot conversations and found that the more humanlike a chatbot was, the more verbal abuse and sexualized comments users produced.[10] Thus, knowing that the object is not human does not automatically make people gentle or make them less aggressive. Human interactions are shaped by habits. Humans do not first consult a philosophical classification chart before deciding whether emotion may be discharged. People are not fully rational.

The freedom objection says: “Even if rudeness affects me, it is still my free choice.” This is true, but it does not answer the question. The issue is not whether a person can be rude to ChatGPT, but whether he should be. A person may have the freedom to make a poor choice, but freedom alone does not make that choice worth defending. John Stuart Mill’s argument in *On Liberty* protects individuals from coercion; it does not require us to treat every self-regarding choice as equally intelligent or self-preserving. If I govern my speech only when another person can complain, then my agency is being regulated from outside, by consequence and retaliation, rather than from inside, by standards I can maintain.[11]

The fourth opposing argument turns to practical reality: insulting AI is a healthy release, and it makes me feel better. But Brad J. Bushman’s experiments in 1999 and 2002 repeatedly showed that venting while ruminating does not reliably reduce anger[12] and may instead increase later aggression.[13] Furthermore, Kjærvik and Bushman’s 2024 meta-analysis in Clinical Psychology Review, which covered 154 studies, 184 independent samples, and 10,189 participants,[14] concludes that activities lowering physiological arousal reduce anger more effectively, while arousal-increasing “venting” activities lack stabilizing effects. In other words, “I will feel better once I insult it out” is not reliable psychology.

When this evidence is brought back into the ChatGPT context, the problem becomes even more serious. ChatGPT-style venting takes the form of a continuous cycle. The bot repeatedly responds, continues erring, continues apologizing, and continues generating new errors. The user thinks he is pouring fire onto a painless object, but in fact may be entering a rumination loop: The more gentle the bot’s responses to the user’s anger, the more absurd it seems; the more absurd it seems, the more anger the user feels. Short-term pleasure generated by expressing one’s anger is swallowed by attention loss and emotional contradiction. Therefore, in relation to a non-moral object, politeness is not about morality, but also about efficiency.

The replacement objection says: “Even if venting at ChatGPT does not reduce anger, it may still redirect aggression away from real people.” That claim works only if two conditions are met: anger at a machine must actually replace aggression in interpersonal relations, and one expression of anger does not increase the likelihood of another. But neither condition has been proven. Bushman’s experiments show precisely that venting with rumination about an object preserves and amplifies hostility; chatbots also keep producing new responses, causing the user to reattach anger to an object. So-called substitution may therefore become rehearsal, instead of releasing aggression, the user is practicing how to enter an aggression state more quickly.

AI does not necessarily create new bad desires. More often, it lowers the cost of old behavior. Rudeness is not new, but AI lowers the cost of rudeness. There is no consequence of a broken relationship, only an interface that continues to respond.

3.Private Rudeness Enters a Feedback System

Private rudeness toward ChatGPT is not always purely private. A person cursing a table trains only himself; a person cursing a chatbot enters a feedback system. The interface responds, adapts, and is shaped by patterns of use. It gives a social-looking scene without social resistance. Therefore, the issue is no longer only whether rudeness damages the user’s own self-command, but whether repeated rude interactions teach the system to handle contempt more smoothly, making that pattern easier for other users to enter.

This does not mean that an individual insult is automatically incorporated into the model, or that every rude input directly trains ChatGPT. The point is that conversational AI exists inside feedback systems. Bai et al.’s RLHF paper shows that dialogue models are trained through human preference feedback to become more helpful and harmless assistants. This does not prove that insulting is rewarded, but it does show that AI output is not absolutely neutral; it is shaped by human interaction, and feedback mechanisms.

The CHI 2020 study *Empathy Is All You Need* also shows that a conversational agent’s response to verbal abuse affects user emotion, empathetic responses can make users less angry and more guilty. This matters because the system’s response is not passive. It helps shape the next interaction: if a chatbot learns, or is designed, to receive rudeness smoothly, the user may find that contempt works as an input method.

This is why the privacy of the act does not end the normative question. The machine is not harmed, but the interaction is not empty. It shapes the user who speaks, and it may help shape the environment in which other users will speak. A rude user may think he is only insulting a painless object. In fact, he may be participating in the creation of an interface where contempt becomes easier, smoother, and more socially available.

Conclusion

AI is a probabilistic model. Apology and gentleness are only code-generated; but the attention spent and the repeated entry into emotional states belong to a real person, and expressive habits will inevitably be trained by the system. Human loss of control can be processed by feedback.

Insulting ChatGPT matters because a consequence-free interface can train the user to treat degradation as an available response. The issue is not only self-command, but ownership -- whether a person can still govern and answer for his expression when a system makes loss of control feel consequence-free. The relevant “should” is an internal standard of agency. A free person should be able to maintain command over his speech even in the lowest-cost environment. The person using ChatGPT needs the small discipline that politeness preserves.

The “should” here is an internal norm of responsible agency; if you claim that freedom in using a tool, you must also answer for how that use shapes the person you become. We should be polite to ChatGPT not because ChatGPT deserves politeness, but because politeness helps the user preserve self-command. ChatGPT is not harmed. But through one’s own choices, a person may harm one’s own self-command, and even lose the capacity to bear consequences. ChatGPT does not need politeness; the user needs the small discipline that politeness turns into habit.

End Notes & Reference

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